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Banking in Korea for Foreigners

Step-by-step guide to opening a Korean bank account, choosing the right bank, using mobile banking, and sending money abroad.

Which Bank Should You Choose?

Not all Korean banks are equally foreigner-friendly. Here are the best options based on language support, documentation requirements, and mobile app quality.

IBK 기업은행

Best for Foreigners

Most foreigner-friendly bank in Korea. Many branches near universities have English-speaking staff. Accepts ARC alone (no Korean guarantor needed).

KEB Hana 하나은행

International Transfers

Excellent for international wire transfers. Has dedicated foreigner banking services at major branches. Good mobile app.

Shinhan 신한은행

Widely Available

Many ATMs and branches nationwide. SOL app is well-designed. Usually accepts ARC + passport. Popular with long-term expats.

KakaoBank 카카오뱅크

App-Only

100% mobile bank — no physical branches. Fast setup if you have ARC + Korean phone number. Best UI/UX of any Korean bank. Highly

Woori 우리은행

Solid Option

Large nationwide presence. Good for long-term residents. Has English menus on ATMs and online banking.

Toss Bank 토스뱅크

App-Only

Simple, clean mobile bank. Great for daily spending and transfers between Korean accounts. Requires Korean phone number and ARC.

recommended as secondary account.



How to Open a Bank Account — Step by Step

1

Get your ARC (Alien Registration Card) first

Without an ARC, most banks won't open an account. Apply at the local Immigration Office (출입국관리사무소) within 90 days of arrival. Takes 2–3 weeks to process. Some banks accept passport only for tourist accounts — but these are very limited.

2

Prepare your documents

Required: ARC + passport. Some banks may also ask for: proof of address (residence certificate or rental contract), employment certificate (재직증명서) if employed, or student certificate (재학증명서) if a student.

3

Visit an IBK or Shinhan branch in person

Go to a branch near a university — staff are more experienced with foreigners. Avoid very small rural branches. Morning weekdays are quietest. Tell them you want to open a 입출금통장 (basic deposit account).

4

Fill out the application form

Most major banks have English forms or bilingual staff. Fill in your name, ARC number, address, and phone number. You'll choose a PIN for your bank card (체크카드).

5

Get your bank card and set up mobile banking

Your debit card (체크카드) arrives immediately or within a week by post. Download the bank's app. You'll need to verify with your Korean phone number via OTP (one-time password). Many apps also work with fingerprint or face ID.



Best strategy: Open an IBK account in person for your main account (salary, rent), then add KakaoBank as a secondary account for daily spending and easy transfers. KakaoBank setup takes 10 minutes on your phone.



Sending Money Abroad

Korean banks offer wire transfers but fees and rates vary. Third-party services are usually cheaper.

SERVICE	FEE	SPEED	BEST FOR
Wise (위즈)	~0.4–1%	1–2 days	Best overall rate. Most popular with expats.
KEB Hana Wire	₩5,000 + FX margin	1–3 days	Reliable bank transfer to most countries
Shinhan Wire	₩5,000–10,000	1–3 days	Good for large amounts
Moneygram / Western Union	Higher fees	Minutes	Cash pickup in recipient country

⚠ **Important:** Korea has strict foreign exchange laws. Transfers over \$10,000 USD per transaction may require proof of the source of funds. Large transfers (over \$50,000/year) need documentation. Use Wise for regular smaller transfers — it's easiest and cheapest.

Using ATMs in Korea

ATM TIPS

- **7-Eleven, GS25, CU** convenience store ATMs: Accept most foreign Visa/Mastercard cards. Available 24/7.
- **Global ATMs** (글로벌 ATM): Found at airports, major subway stations, tourist areas — press English and select your language.
- **Withdrawal limit:** Usually ₩700,000–1,000,000 per transaction for foreign cards.
- **Fees:** Your home bank charges ~\$3–5 per withdrawal. Korean ATM adds ~₩1,000 fee after hours.
- **Best hack:** Open a Wise card before arriving — use it like a local card at any ATM in Korea with great exchange rates.

Banking Korean Phrases

통장 개설하고 싶어요. *tong-jang gae-seol-ha-go si-peo-yo.* I'd like to open a bank account.

체크카드 만들어 주세요. *che-keu-ka-deu man-deu-reo ju-se-yo.* Please make me a debit card.

잔액이 얼마예요? *jan-aeg-i eol-ma-ye-yo?* What is my balance?

해외 송금하고 싶어요. *hae-oe song-geum-ha-go si-peo-yo.* I'd like to send money abroad.

비밀번호를 바꾸고 싶어요. *bi-mil-beon-ho-reul ba-kku-go si-peo-yo.* I'd like to change my PIN.

카드를 잃어버렸어요. *ka-deu-reul i-reo-beo-ryeo-sseo-yo.* I lost my card.

Living in Korea long-term?

Learn the Korean you need for banking, daily conversations and workplace life — 41 chapters.

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